

Chapter 45-2: Solitude

Opposite the bronze door was the underworld, from which came gusts of cold wind along with faint ghostly wails. Chu Qingqiu's hand tightened as she secured the white bone at her waist.

The judge mumbled some unclear incantations, his pale finger pointing toward Ning Fuyi. Ning Fuyi's body quickly shrank, then rose into the air with the wind, crashing into Chu Qingqiu's embrace with a *thud*.

The body of a golden hamster was still very difficult to control. Ning Fuyi stretched out her two small claws and scrambled for a long time, finally grabbing onto Chu Qingqiu's ear to barely steady herself.

"Ning Fuyi!" Chu Qingqiu couldn't help but scold. Just as Ning Fuyi was about to apologize, the bronze door suddenly burst open, and countless blood-stained hands reached out from within, dragging the two of them inside.

Qiu Yi's screams abruptly stopped, and those hands also disappeared. They were now standing on a plank bridge. This bridge was very narrow, only able to accommodate three people side by side, but it was very long - so long that they couldn't see the end.

Countless ghosts were passing across the bridge with vacant stares, crowded together. From time to time, ghosts would be pushed off the bridge and fall silently.

Ning Fuyi bounced on Chu Qingqiu's shoulder, grabbing her hair to look down. When she saw clearly the river flowing beneath the bridge, she immediately squeaked.

In the pitch-black water surface, one pale face after another appeared, bloated from soaking, drifting with the current toward some unknown distant place. The scene was both tranquil and eerie.

Ning Fuyi tugged at Chu Qingqiu's hair, wanting her to look down. Chu Qingqiu tilted her head slightly and said with barely contained patience: "Just think it, I can hear what you're saying."

"Below." Ning Fuyi tried using divine consciousness to speak. Sure enough, Chu Qingqiu followed her gaze to look under the bridge, her face instantly turning pale.

"This is the River of Forgetting¹." Chu Qingqiu said.

"Yes." The judge floating in mid-air suddenly spoke. His face had returned to a normal human state, quite clean and fair, only excessively so. "Usually not so many ghosts fall into the River of Forgetting, but now the Yellow Springs Road² is completely packed with ghosts, so crowded they can't move, and they keep falling in."

He sighed: "Many who should enter reincarnation will never be able to transcend, how pitiful."

As soon as he finished speaking, his clean face suddenly became stained with blood again, his eyes were gouged out, his tongue stretched down with a *pop*, and he let out a piercing scream toward the blocked area ahead. Chu Qingqiu's face turned even paler, and she tightly closed her eyes.

Hearing this scream, the ghosts scattered in fear. Some fell into the River of Forgetting, others crowded forward, finally clearing the path.

"Sorry." The judge's face returned to normal, and he smiled with satisfaction.

At this moment, the bronze bell at his waist suddenly rang *ding ling ling*. The judge's expression changed, and he hurriedly said: "Another ghost has escaped from the mortal realm. I must go catch it. The yang energy on Divine Venerable's body can only provide cover for seven days. After seven days, this little immortal friend will also be exposed. I will return before then to bring you out of the underworld."

"Remember, you two must not leave each other's side for even a moment."

As soon as he finished speaking, the judge's figure disappeared, leaving only faint firefly light in mid-air.

Chu Qingqiu was bumped by a ghost. She quickly stepped aside, watching the ghost that bumped into her walk past. This ghost had died miserably in life - half its intestines were hanging outside, dragging on the ground as it walked.

Ning Fuyi watched with great interest, while Chu Qingqiu kept retreating.

"Divine Venerable, look at that one." Ning Fuyi stood on Chu Qingqiu's shoulder, pointing to a person in the distance who had been torn apart by horses³ - his body, limbs, and head were each moving separately, hopping about on the ground.

"Stop looking. We only have seven days and no time to wander around." Chu Qingqiu's voice was strange, as if she was about to vomit. However, just as she tried to take flight, thousands of ghost faces on the Yellow Springs Road suddenly turned toward them. The scene was indescribably terrifying.

Chu Qingqiu let her hand drop and landed back on the bridge, and only then did those ghost faces turn away.

Seeing this, Ning Fuyi stretched out her small claw, and light pink immortal power flowed from her palm. The ghost souls again turned to look at them in unison. This time they didn't just look - they swarmed over densely. Soon there were *splash splash* sounds as they fell into the river.

Ning Fuyi alternately used and withdrew her immortal power, making all the ghosts on the bridge turn back and forth like marionettes. Only then did she stop, whispering in Chu Qingqiu's ear:

"Divine Venerable, it seems we can't use immortal power, or they'll detect us."

"I saw." Chu Qingqiu said as she stepped forward, blending into the crowd of ghosts and walking along the edge of the bridge.

"This ghost judge didn't even mention that we can't use immortal power. The underworld isn't just this one place in the netherworld. If we encounter some powerful evil ghost, won't we be doomed?" Ning Fuyi sat down on Chu Qingqiu's shoulder, grabbing her earlobe to steady herself while dangling her feet.

Being transformed into a golden hamster was quite fun - at least she didn't have to walk herself, Ning Fuyi thought.

Chu Qingqiu didn't reply or tell Ning Fuyi to let go. She just walked quickly through the sea of ghosts. After walking for an unknown amount of time, they finally saw the end of the bridge.

Ahead was an extremely wide riverbank. As the judge had said, it was packed with ghosts, heads bobbing like a dense anthill.

The ghosts here weren't as orderly as those on the bridge - they wandered east and west, all looking anxious, with resentful energy hitting them head-on.

Chu Qingqiu had already gripped the white bone tightly. She closed her eyes, planning to walk through them, when suddenly a long-tongued ghost turned a corner and slid rapidly toward her.

The bloody head instantly enlarged. Chu Qingqiu's face turned deathly pale as she dodged, involuntarily about to draw the white bone. Seeing this, Ning Fuyi quickly supported herself on her short legs to stand up, using the golden hamster's voice to let out a piercing shriek at the ghost.

The ghost immediately recoiled in terror upon hearing that sound. At the same time, other ghosts also made way for them, and the resentful energy around them immediately thinned.

Chu Qingqiu was breathing rapidly, as if greatly frightened, slowly putting away the white bone.

Ning Fuyi was close enough to hear Chu Qingqiu's heartbeat like thunder. She hesitated for a moment, then suddenly hopped to the front of the woman, grabbing her clothes and looking into her eyes with her small black ones.

"Divine Venerable, are you afraid of ghosts?" she asked with a curved smile.

Footnotes:

¹ **River of Forgetting (忘川河):** In Chinese mythology, souls who fall into this river lose their memories and cannot be reincarnated

² **Yellow Springs Road (黄泉路):** The path that souls take to the underworld after death in Chinese mythology

³ **Torn apart by horses (车裂):** An ancient Chinese execution method where the victim was tied to horses or chariots that pulled in different directions